European Conference on Domestic Violence

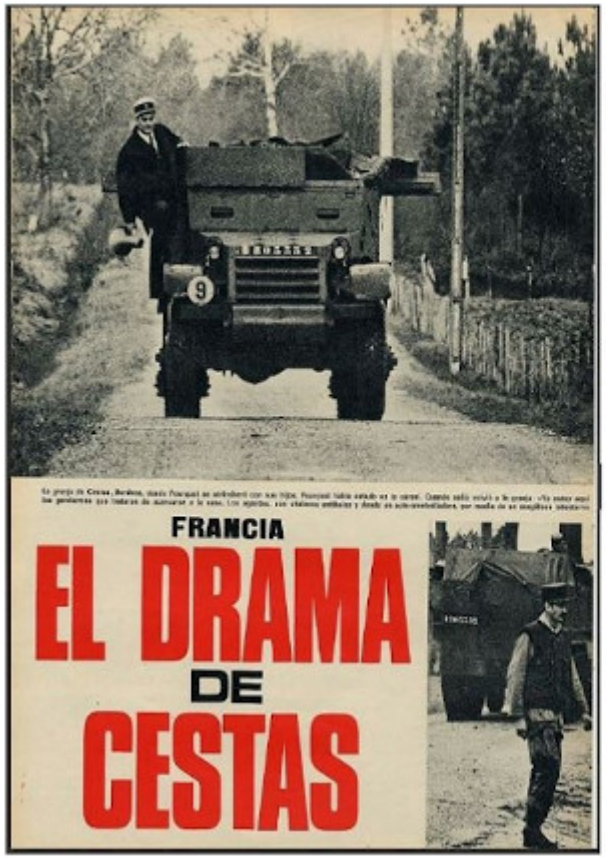
How is Parental Alienation Used Against Separated and Divorced Mothers in France

Pierre-Guillaume Prigent & Gwénola Sueur
University of Western Brittany / University of Angers
2 september 2019

> Mothers are considered responsible for everything that happens to their children and, by extension, the evils of the world. This is a powerful idea in common sense ('it's not surprising, with a mother like that!'), which has been taken up and legitimised by various experts. (Romito, 2008)

- *A historical overview*
  - The spread of PAS in France
  - Feminists and mothers activists's resistance
- *Our study*
  - Background
  - Methodology
  - Analysis

February 1969



Year	Fathers' Rights Group creation	Event
1969	DIDHEM	André Fourquet kills two of his children before killing himself
1974	MCMP, Mouvement pour la Condition Masculine et Paternelle	
1977	FMCP, Fédération des Mouvements de la Condition Paternelle	
1986		'Viols Femmes Informations' free rape line is created
1990	SOS Papa	
1996		Dutroux case; children speak about incest
1999	Collectif des pères de Pontoise	Enveff, first national survey on VAW in France
2002		SOS Papa law (shared custody) is voted
1997-2003		Two hundred doctors were prosecuted and sanctioned by the CNOM

Catherine Bonnet

L'Express, april 1999

Divorce

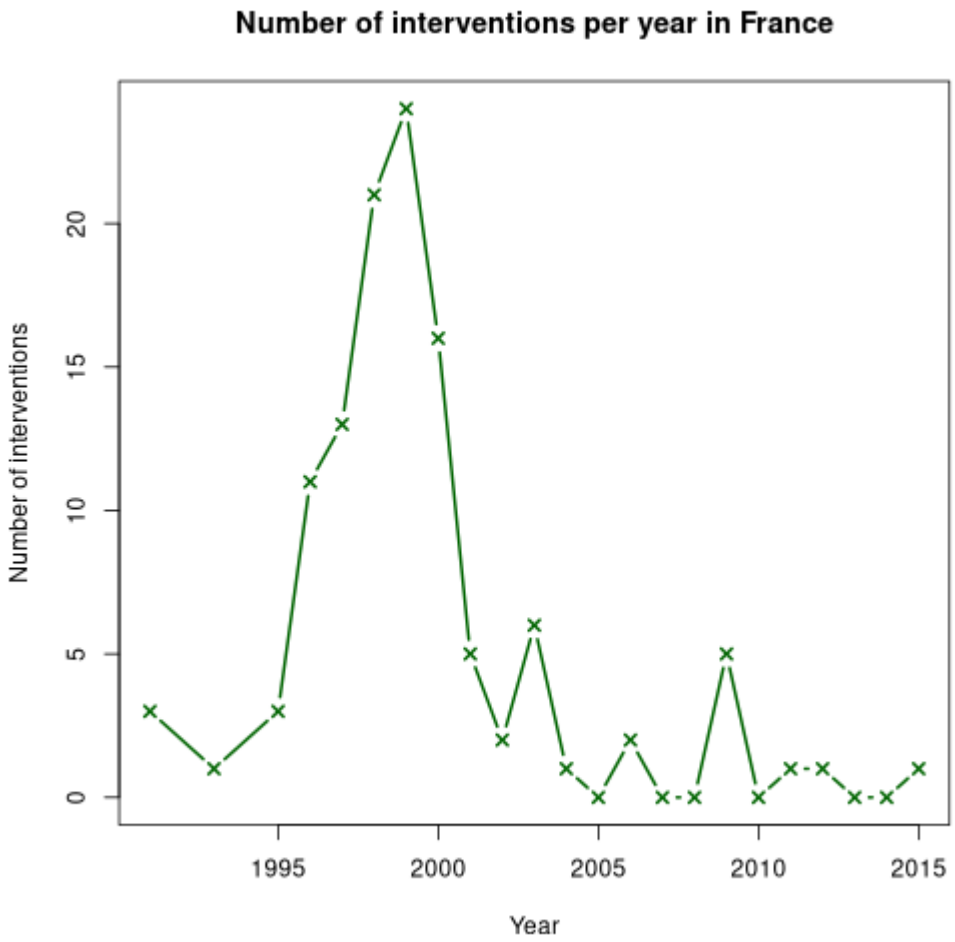
L'arme du soupçon

Un inquiétant phénomène semble gagner les prétoires français : des centaines de pères se voient accuser, parfois à tort, du pire des crimes. Certains y perdent leur emploi, leur honneur et l'amour de leurs enfants. Histoires vécues

Gilbert Charles

Photos : J.-P. Guilloteau/L'Express

Hubert Van Gijseghem's interventions



Paul Bensussan, 1999

> Parental alienation refers to a psychological condition in which a child allies himself or herself strongly with an alienating (or preferred) parent and rejects a relationship with the alienated (or targeted) parent without legitimate justification. (Bernet *et al.*, 2019)

> For our children, for their children, for our judges of tomorrow, for our presidents, our social workers, our ministers, for our citizens, and for all those who will still suffer, we, mothers in struggle, are determined today to fight, again and again. Until one day our children may no longer be afraid. (1999)

French Ministry of Justice informs about the PAS' lack of scientific foundations

Action 58 : Informer sur le caractère médicalement infondé du « syndrome d'aliénation parentale »

Dans les cas de violences conjugales ou de violences faites aux enfants, l'allégation du « syndrome d'aliénation parentale » soulève de réelles difficultés. Elle conduit à décrédibiliser la parole de la mère, exceptionnellement du père ou de l'enfant, et par conséquent à en nier le statut de victime en inversant les responsabilités. Or, aucune autorité scientifique n'a jamais reconnu un tel « syndrome » et le consensus scientifique souligne le manque de fiabilité de cette notion. Il n'est reconnu ni par le Manuel diagnostique et statistique des troubles mentaux (DSM5) ouvrage de référence de l'association américaine de psychiatrie (APA), ni par la classification internationale des maladies publiée par l'Organisation mondiale de la santé (OMS). La recherche démontre que les fausses allégations de maltraitance ou de négligences sur les enfants sont marginales.
C'est pourquoi une communication visant à proscrire l'utilisation de ce concept sera réalisée, via la publication d'une fiche sur ce sujet, sur le site du Ministère de la justice.

- Calendrier : 2017
- Pilote : Ministère en charge des droits des femmes, Ministère des familles
- Contributeur.trice.s : Ministère en charge des droits des femmes, Ministère de la Justice, Ministère de la Santé

'Parental alienation', first findings

- there is a context of parental separation
- the father sexually abuses his children
- he eventually gets the children's custody by accusing the mother of being 'alienating'

'Parental alienation', second findings

- the accusation did not provoke the custody change
- children are not systematically sexually abused but can be victims of domestic or other types of violence
- 'parental alienation' is not systematically mentioned, but the idea of a 'delusional' mother is

Is parental alienation a strategy to hide domestic violence?

Read Côté, Lapierre, & Dupuis-Déri, 2019 📚

> A sensitive topic is one 'that potentially poses for those involved a substantial threat, the emergence of which renders problematic for the researcher and/or the researched the collection, holding, and/or dissemination of research data' (Lee and Renzetti, 1993, p. 5).

Data about the interviews (by phone)

- Women interviewed: 13 (7+6)
- Total duration of interviews (in hours): 16:20
- Average duration: 1:25
- Minimum duration: 0:48
- Maximum duration: 1:49

Agressor's strategy (Marie-France Casalis, CFCV*)

- Isolate the victim
- Denigrate her
- Reverse the guilt
- Create a climate of fear and insecurity
- Organise his impunity

**Collectif Féministe Contre le Viol, Feminist Collective Against Rape*

Accusations can be initiated or sustained by:

- The father
- The father's family
- Professionnals who support the father
- Father's Rights Groups
- Psychiatry experts
- Judges and social workers

Court of Appeal Order

> 'it appears, in the present case, that the mother keeps the daughter without cause in order to prevent the father from seeing her normally and regularly. That this behaviour is likely to develop in the child manifestation entitled by specialists of 'Parental Alienation Syndrome' and may place the girl in great danger'.

2 groups of women

- Women who can rely on socio-cultural resources to help them against the accusation
  - They do not lose custody
- Women who can't rely on such resources to help them
  - They lose custody

! *This needs to be confirmed by further research*

One of the women we interviewed

> 'I have a label and no matter what I do, it's there.'

A judge, while the child has reported sexual violence and the investigation is ongoing

> Madam obstructs the father's rights, the persistence of her accusations is considered worrying, she 'refuses to take into account the psychological distress of the father'. The mother is said to be 'blinded by her victim position, which prevents her from reflecting on her own functioning and the difficulties she causes, systematically blaming the father'.

Thank you for listening!

If you want to contact us:

Pierre-Guillaume Prigent: ppg@protonmail.com

Gwénola Sueur: gwenola.sueur@gmail.com

Watch Prigent & Sueur, 2018